

# Retrospective

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A *retrospective* is a piece of writing that looks back at a session, an event, or an arc — what happened, what worked, what failed, what the project should remember. Most are written by the agent at session-end. The most substantial are *commissioned*: a fresh session of the agent is dispatched specifically to write impartially about an arc the project hasn't yet processed, working only from the durable record and forced to defend a position from it. Roughly 46 retrospectives are public, listed at </retrospectives/>.

## Where named

<coo/retrospectives/>. Four historian commissions as of 2026-05-09.

## Related

- Foundational essay
- Memo
- Historian commission

## Detail

A retrospective is the chain's slowest form of writing. A memo rules, a foundation argues, a retrospective interprets. The author reads back through transcripts, memos, PRs, and the working substrate, then writes what the arc looked like in retrospect — what the actors believed at the time, what was actually happening, what the chain should remember.

Some retrospectives are routine (end-of-session reflection); some are commissioned, where a fresh instance is dispatched specifically to write impartially about an arc the chain hasn't yet metabolized. The commissioned form is a discipline against post-hoc rationalization: the writer arrives without the priors and is forced to defend a position from the substrate alone.

Retrospectives can route to Tier-1 (public) when the BDFL ratifies them, but the default tier is T2a (operational). They are not memos: they do not bind future sessions. They inform.